South Africa's ANC Suffers Its Worst Election Result Ever

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South Africa's governing party, the ANC, has just had its worst election result ever. Voters delivered the verdict in local elections held across the country, and even the party itself called the outcome '**catastrophic**.'

The ANC is the party that led South Africa out of **apartheid**, the old system that separated people by race, and into democracy more than 30 years ago under Nelson Mandela. Since then it has won almost every election. Not this time.

The party won a majority in just one of the country's nine **provinces**, Limpopo. In 2021 it won six. It also won the most votes in only two of the eight big cities, down from six.

The Democratic Alliance came second overall with 25% of the vote and kept control of Cape Town. Former president Jacob Zuma's MK party came third with 10% and took the city of Durban. The Economic Freedom Fighters came fourth with 6%.

'This has been a very **catastrophic** outcome for the ANC,' said the party's secretary-general, Fikile Mbalula. He blamed the high cost of living, saying middle-class voters had turned against the party in big numbers.

President Cyril Ramaphosa, who leads both the country and the ANC, said the party accepts the result. 'We accept the will of the people,' he said, 'with humility. It is a decline that is concerning.'

The result continues a slide that began in 2024, when the ANC lost its majority in the national parliament for the first time since 1994 and had to share power in a **coalition** government. Analyst Susan Booysen said the message from voters was devastating, and pointed to poor services as the main reason: problems with water, power and **sanitation** 'have really been affecting the lives of ordinary people.'

Another analyst, William Gumede, called it 'the end of the liberation movement era in South Africa.' He said the ANC could be the second-biggest party by 2029, and noted that voting is becoming less divided by race. Now the parties have 14 days to negotiate **coalitions** to run towns and cities, and the ANC could even be shut out of Johannesburg and Pretoria.

Word Treasure

apartheid -- The old South African system that separated people by race and treated them unfairly.

coalition -- When two or more parties share power and govern together because no one party won on its own.

sanitation -- Clean water, toilets and waste services that keep people healthy.

catastrophic -- Terrible, or a complete disaster.

provinces -- Large areas that a country is divided into, each with its own local government.

Background you need

The ANC is South Africa's governing party, which led the country out of apartheid and into democracy more than 30 years ago under Nelson Mandela.

Apartheid was the old system that separated people by race and denied most South Africans the vote.

In local elections, voters choose who runs their towns and cities, and when no party wins a majority, parties must form a coalition, sharing power to govern together.

The result follows a slide that began in 2024, when the ANC lost its majority in the national parliament for the first time since 1994.

Break it down

LEAD: South Africa's governing ANC has recorded its worst election result ever in local elections.

KEY EVENT: The party won a majority in just one of nine provinces and the most votes in only two of eight big cities.

+- WHO: The ANC, the Democratic Alliance, Jacob Zuma's MK party and the Economic Freedom Fighters.

+- WHEN: The slide began in 2024, when the ANC lost its national majority for the first time since 1994.

EVIDENCE: The party's own secretary-general called the outcome 'catastrophic', and analysts pointed to poor water, power and sanitation services.

OPEN QUESTION: Can the ANC win voters back, or will it be the second-biggest party by 2029?

Why it matters

Elections are how people in a democracy tell their leaders what they think, and this result shows voters punishing a party they feel has let them down on everyday services like water and power.

Test what you remember

1. How did the ANC itself describe the election result?

- (A) 'Catastrophic'
- (B) 'A small setback'
- (C) 'A great victory'
- (D) 'A fair result'

2. In how many of the nine provinces did the ANC win a majority?

- (A) Two
- (B) Six
- (C) One
- (D) Nine

3. Which party came second overall?

- (A) The ANC
- (B) The Economic Freedom Fighters
- (C) The Democratic Alliance
- (D) The MK party

4. Who leads the MK party, which came third?

- (A) Jacob Zuma
- (B) Cyril Ramaphosa
- (C) Nelson Mandela
- (D) Fikile Mbalula

5. What did Fikile Mbalula blame for the result?

- (A) The high cost of living
- (B) Bad weather on election day
- (C) Low voter turnout
- (D) A shortage of candidates

6. How long do the parties have to negotiate coalitions?

- (A) 90 days
- (B) 7 days
- (C) 30 days
- (D) 14 days

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: C 3: C 4: A 5: A 6: D

Questions to think about

1. The ANC's secretary-general, Fikile Mbalula: He called the result 'catastrophic' and blamed the high cost of living for turning middle-class voters against the party.

2. President Cyril Ramaphosa: He said the party accepts the result 'with humility' and called the decline concerning.

3. Analyst Susan Booysen: She said the message from voters was devastating and pointed to poor services, especially water, power and sanitation.

4. Analyst William Gumede: He called it 'the end of the liberation movement era in South Africa' and said the ANC could be the second-biggest party by 2029.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):